

SpaceX's Biggest Starship Ever Is About to Blast Off!

From: Space.com Mined: 2026-05-18 3 min read

Get ready for a sky show! SpaceX is about to launch the biggest, newest version of its Starship rocket the **Starship V3**. This thing is a monster: it's the tallest and most powerful rocket ever built. And it's finally flying again after seven long months. The launch is set for Wednesday, May 20, at 6:30 p.m. Eastern Time from SpaceX's Starbase in Texas. This is Flight 12, the 12th test flight of Starship since 2023, but the very first one this year. So what's the big deal? **Starship V3** has lots of upgrades to make it better than before. During this test, the rocket will soar partway around Earth on a **suborbital** path. The upper part, called Ship, will then splash down in the Indian Ocean. Along the way, it'll release 20 dummy **Starlink satellites** pretend versions of the real internet satellites SpaceX launches and two special cameras that will beam back photos of the Ship in space. That sounds like a sci-fi movie! Why does this matter? NASA is counting on Starship to land astronauts on the Moon in 2028. SpaceX also wants to use Starship to launch huge numbers of **Starlink satellites** and maybe even build data centers in orbit. But first, they have to prove it works. So far, Starship hasn't carried real cargo to orbit, but each test flight gets them closer. Future flights might try to catch the giant **booster** with '**Mechazilla**' a huge tower with metal arms at the launch pad. That's how SpaceX plans to make Starship fully **reusable**, like a giant airplane for space. Fingers crossed for a smooth launch and splashdown!

Word Treasure

Starship V3 -- The newest, biggest version of SpaceX's rocket.

suborbital -- A path that goes partway around Earth but not into a full orbit.

Starlink satellites -- Internet satellites that SpaceX builds to provide global internet.

Mechazilla -- A giant tower with metal arms that catches rocket boosters.

reusable -- Able to be used again and again, like an airplane.

booster -- The lower part of a rocket that gives it the first big push off the ground.

Background you need

SpaceX (a company founded by Elon Musk) has been developing reusable rockets to make space travel cheaper.

Starbase, located in Boca Chica, Texas, is where SpaceX builds and tests its Starship rockets.

Starlink satellites already provide internet to remote areas around the world.

Break it down

WHO: SpaceX

WHAT: Launching the Starship V3, its biggest rocket, on a test flight to release dummy satellites and cameras, with a splashdown in the Indian Ocean

WHERE: From SpaceX's Starbase in Texas, flying a suborbital path to the Indian Ocean

WHY: To test upgrades, eventually prove it can carry astronauts to the Moon, and make space travel routine and reusable

Why it matters

This giant rocket could one day carry people to the Moon or even help provide worldwide internet from space, so the future of space travel might be just like science fiction--and you might watch it happen live!

Test what you remember

1. When is the launch scheduled?

- ☐ (A) A) Thursday, May 21
- ☐ (B) B) Wednesday, May 20
- ☐ (C) C) Friday, May 22
- ☐ (D) D) Saturday, May 23

2. What is the name of the rocket?

- ☐ (A) A) Falcon 9
- ☐ (B) B) Starship V3
- ☐ (C) C) Moon Lander
- ☐ (D) D) Space Shuttle

3. What will the ship release during the test?

- ☐ (A) A) Real astronauts
- ☐ (B) B) 20 dummy Starlink satellites and two cameras
- ☐ (C) C) A Mars rover
- ☐ (D) D) A giant mirror

4. Where will the upper part splash down?

- ☐ (A) A) Atlantic Ocean
- ☐ (B) B) Pacific Ocean
- ☐ (C) C) Indian Ocean
- ☐ (D) D) Arctic Ocean

5. What is Mechazilla?

- ☐ (A) A) A giant robot dinosaur
- ☐ (B) B) A launch pad tower with arms to catch the booster
- ☐ (C) C) A new video game
- ☐ (D) D) A space telescope

6. Why is Starship important for NASA?

- ☐ (A) A) To send a robot to Pluto
- ☐ (B) B) To land astronauts on the Moon
- ☐ (C) C) To catch a comet
- ☐ (D) D) To build a space hotel

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Positive:** SpaceX and NASA see it as a big step toward returning humans to the Moon and making space more accessible.
2. **Critical:** Some people worry about the noise and environmental impact of such big rockets, or that it's moving too fast without enough safety testing.
3. **Neutral:** Space experts are watching to see if the new upgrades work, which will decide the next steps for lunar missions.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):